

Weal and Dove

Weal did not wish to die. Not truly. Not beyond the concept of it and the preemptive goodness of her end. She would have given her heart or gold or anything else, and may have even given her mind with a bit of cajoling. But Dove did not cajole her, and the mind did not suffice. Instead Dove took a heavy, flat-bottomed rock to her head and next she knew, she lay face-up in the dirt. The hill was cold and windy. And the firmament was gunmetal grey, swollen with coming rain like the loose flesh of a water birth. She hadn't long to think.

One by one, shovelfuls of soil came down on her body, spattering worms and wetness over the woman's face — eyebrows slightly knitted, sight somewhere far off; fixed not on Dove, but the cruel Earth-Mother who permitted such actions in her name.

Weal considered screaming, but she knew it would hurt the two of them; she in the Underworld, Weal tormented by Her wrath, and perhaps it would be better to pass through holy lips as a saint than a victim. Her last breath was sacrifice. Precipitated love.



Dove and his pilgrims crafted the church with walls cedar-hewn, arches open like the branches of a welcome tree, unbreaking under storm and torrent and successful at last. All for Weal's graces. Soon more settlers arrived, and their lives sprouted from the fertile soil in which she laid— but still, Dove was unhappy. He spent long hours pacing under moon-drunk stars and swore to the Mother that he could hear Weal's whispers tugging at his tunic. Pleading.

To what end he did not know until he ordered the soil cleared, a pit before the pulpit. He pressed his cheek against her cold chest —divine in preservation, fabric not even a bit wrinkled, smelling of sweet and sour stasis— and begged her to rise once more, for once the deed passed it could not be undone.

Weal and Dove, two bodies, appeared a dual-fold thing connected at the chest; shadow against stone ceiling, not unlike her day of burial. Then Weal drew breath and rose, hands outstretched. Her shuddering lids were not entirely hers, glazed with knowledge that no man nor woman should return from. A long and terrible torture had befallen her. She spoke, gripping Dove's wrists in the vice of the dead;

“There is no Underworld nor Overworld, and Mother is not as you expect.”

Weal clawed at the air and began to rise from her grave, but Dove called frantically for dirt; for silver coins to weigh her mania and keep her soul abreast. No apologies did pass.

Clerics, as requested, heaped heavy blankets upon her still-moving corpse. Her lids were shut; mouth sewn up. Dove refreshed her pit with wood, vowing to never speak of the moment again or feel as he did on the spur. He had learnt an unwelcome verse, but hope had already been sown— and if it were true... If it were true...

With no choice but to believe, Dove cast her words into the sea.

The church lived even longer than he.

Basin and Being

It was a post-rainy day. Beads of humidity held themselves suspended in the air and formed great wide swaths of cloud above. Below lay scrubby hills as far as the eye could see— so many that each slope and subsequent farmed valley formed a regular, almost mathematical pattern. The nearest hill dipped around its top, and greyish-blue water had accumulated in a shallow basin that drained to nowhere.

Draining to nowhere; an appealing idea to travellers with no agendas.

The weather didn't hurt. But it did bite at noses if left for too long, bare to Mother Nature's machinations; one degree exactly, and chin-numbingly cruel. See, there were two sorts of cold measured in city tourist-speak, and the first was bearable— ordinary winter cold, kept out by fire and hats— while the second seeped into your core and, like a quick broom sweep, penetrated all knitwear. Though it was warmer than the first, with it came hopelessness. Again, no agenda attached.

Halfway up the tallest mountain in all of moorland, three travellers huddled against the brume. They believed that rural vacationing would solve their problems, but they were wrong. Vacations tended to create more problems and destroy more friendships than would otherwise be destroyed. Stopping around a bend where the path had flattened out, the three travellers looked down on what they could see, noting the descent into blue-grey-purple mushiness; fog over heather over placid river. Everything, as if a damper had been placed on the world, was muted in some way or another.

"Tell me about a beautiful place. A real beautiful place," the first traveller offered. They wore ruined brown slacks tucked into rain boots, seemingly having teleported there from some corporate hellscape. In truth, they'd never liked the idea of nine-to-fives (and had never worked at one. The whole concept ruined their artistic vision).

"Beautiful? Absolutely nowhere," the second traveller replied. They rubbed their hands together and tried to create sparks, but it was much too late; their sweater would never let go of the moorish air. At least they'd remember how terrible it all felt. Good writing material.

The third traveller did not speak. They stood, almost invisible, on a mossy rock and watched their reflection in the land below.

"Awfully sad of you. Back when I had work, I went down to Southern California. SoCal, they call it, and spent some nights there. The mountains were just... Gorgeous, yeah, and when the sunsets were all candy-coloured, they'd turn purple. Purple."

"We should've vacationed there instead."

“No chance. Can’t do anything in the United States without money and a good car, and we have neither. Because we’re poor fucks,” the first traveller interjected archly. Perhaps not archly, but artistically, in the way that starving poets speak.

“We’re poor *fucks*.”

A sliver of sunlight managed to escape the sky, favouring a specific farmer’s plot below them. He must’ve sacrificed something for it; shade only dappled the rest. Each hillside, pockmarked and uneven like a wadded-up then unfolded paper towel, remained absent of warmth. The travellers’ mountain-middle was no exception.

“Right on. Now we’re stuck here with nowhere to go, unless we jump off this cliff and do something real sad. The very peak, right? Imagine disappearing together, just the three of us. Then when we get found, everyone will either follow suit or write about the romance of the cursed thing.”

The second traveller laughed. They had considered abandoning ship earlier, right about when the group had visited the basin and looked down to see no fish, only sky, but then they had a reckoning, asking themselves why the hell they’d become an artist if death was the only big achievement at the end. Of course, humans all died and all turned to dust, et cetera, but waiting for it was something else entirely. It involved biding time— like the sleeping giants whose soft, scrub-covered bodies made up the hills.

“I’d want to go home, first,” they replied, “and have a good cup of Earl Grey with cinnamon and milk. And also write my memoir.”

“Memoir? About what?” The first traveller’s right eyebrow rose. Memoirs were awfully boring. Only trauma survivors wrote memoirs. Not flat broke artists standing between a valley and a harder, slightly more heathered hill because they couldn’t bother visiting somewhere normal.

“I got into a spot of trouble five years ago. Planned to start my memoir by chronicling the whole thing, how they told me to “get in the fucking van” because I kept insisting I wasn’t compromised but, of course, wouldn’t breathe into the bag. Then I’d write about my childhood and the allegations, and then,” they paused to point at their nose, which was bright red, “everything else.”

A nippy gust hit the travellers all at once, one push away from sending their scarves flying like plaid flags and tumbling, tumbling, tumbling down to the sunny strip of farmland. There was no good point in hiking if they stopped here forever, deliberating life and death and all. *You can’t live with art hanging over you like a noose*, someone once said, *or you’ll starve off your own fat*.

“That’s horrible. Nobody wants to hear about your licence suspension. Though I guess you could get away with branding it as a, ah, critique of capitalism. It’d be serious that way.”

“Exactly. When you don’t expect something to sell, it’ll sell, so I only have to stop thinking about it and I should be rich come tomorrow. Or whenever the memoir’s done, which shouldn’t take long— see, gloomy weather *is* beautiful. Endless hills get you thinking about where you’ll end, and if you’ll end, and if your stain on the Earth can be washed out or not,” the second traveller offered, visibly happier.

Stains on the Earth. Memoirs. Money and the lack of it. Existing came with far too much semantic baggage, but then again, words were necessary. Nobody could have one without the other. Just like how nobody could live without a carved-out space in reality for these two idiots.

As for the third idiot, who happened to occupy their own separate dimension, they spent quite a while wondering whether the other two were serious or not; serious about their art, poetry, and general goals. Staring out into the pocket of trees that had opened shyly— bordered on either side by heather carpeting— and watching two birds flap from one valley to another, the third traveller polished their glasses.

It’s relative, they thought to themselves. Cold weather does hurt, but the final choice is yours to make; whether you notice the sun or continue stewing in that bitter chill until, some day, your body disappears without a mark.

Not too different from before, nobody noticed the third traveller when they decided to head down the other side of the mountain. Maybe hoping to drown themselves, maybe hoping for nothing at all. Bent like a willow, they shuffled along and closed their ears. Clouds moved overhead and, as it was, no basin nor being had any idea of the future.